

The poem begins with a cosmogony of the kind which we find in the mythological traditions of many races. An allegorical female, called the Daughter of the Air, finds herself in a fair way to become a mother, through the influence of the wind while she is disporting on the surface of the water; but her expectations are so far from speedily fulfilled, that she floats about for 700 years before she increases, or rather commences, the population. In this condition, she offers a prayer to the supreme deity Ukko; and a duck at last appears, and builds upon her knee, which it takes for a mountain, a nest, in which it lays six golden eggs and a seventh of iron. When the eggs have been sat upon for some time, the Water-Mother (as the maiden is now called) feels a painful sensation of burning, and shakes them off, so that they fall into the water. The shells form the upper and lower vaults of the universe, the yolk becomes the sun, the white is coagulated into the moon, some particles are converted into stars and clouds. Raising her head above the flood, the Water-Mother herself creates the various divisions of the land and sea, a touch of her hand forming promontories, her head hollowing out gulfs, and so on. Thirty more years, however, elapse before she gives birth to the son, who is growing weary of his confinement, and is no other than the hero of the poem, Wäinämöinen. At last, rushing into the world by his own exertion, he plunges headlong into the water, where he remains eight years, and ultimately settles on a barren island.

Remaining several years more on this spot, he grows weary of its unfruitful condition; but is at last comforted by a beneficent deity, who is represented as a slender boy, and bears the two names, Pellerwoinen and Samsa. Pellerwoinen sows and plants liberally, and the bare earth is clothed with vegetation, to the great delight of Wäinämöinen, who is, however, disappointed at the non-appearance of the oak. In a few days the deficiency is supplied: the hay which has been made by five "water-maidens" is set on fire by a giant, who rises from the flood, and an acorn is found among the ashes. The oak that now grows proves a source of mischief; for it is so tall, and its branches are so close and wide, that it arrests the passage of the clouds, and shuts out the light of the sun and moon. Wäinämöinen, greatly shocked, calls on his mother for assistance; and in answer to his invocation a little man appears, no taller than his thumb, and clad entirely in copper. He laughs at the diminutive stature of the apparition, which replies by suddenly growing to a colossal height, and felling the oak with three strokes of an axe. The earth now enjoys the blessing of light; and the fragments of the tree, which are borne in all directions by the waters, endow with miraculous powers those who are so fortunate as to find them.

Wandering about, Wäinämöinen finds on the shore of the "Blue Sea" seven grains, which he is going to sow in a woody district, when he is warned by a bird that his labour will be in vain, if he does not first clear away the forest. He accordingly fells all the trees, with the exception of a single birch, which he leaves as a resting-place for the